MAJORS & MINDSETS · FRESHMAN ACADEMY

How do you *open a can?*

You don’t know what you don’t know



Let me start with a joke. →

Pedram Jahangiry
Data Analytics & Information Systems

HUNTSMAN SCHOOL OF BUSINESS · NOV 13, 2026

STRANDED ON AN ISLAND

One can of beans. *No can opener.*



The physicist

rock · 4 m · 9 m/s · hit the rim at 30°

The chemist

sun? too slow → fire → 120 °C steam → pressure ×2 → the seam pops

The economist

hasn’t said a word.

And the economist says… →

THE ECONOMIST

“Let’s assume we have a can opener.”

Six years of my PhD: assume the hard part away, then ask the real question.

Then what?

You have the opener. What do you want to open? →

HAVEN'T PICKED A MAJOR YET? I'VE PICKED FOUR.

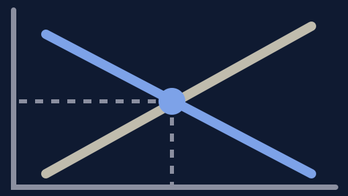
It's not the major. *It's the mindset.*

FIRST
Industrial Engineering



→

PHD
Economics



→

BLACKROCK
Finance



→

NOW
Data



I dare you: explore other majors until you find a can you'd love to open.

Not sure what you want yet? Totally normal. →

You don’t know what you don’t know



Known knowns

You know exactly what you want. Great. Let’s confirm it.



Known unknowns

You picked Huntsman. Eight majors. Not sure what’s inside.



↑ TODAY’S GOAL

Unknown knowns

You’re good at something. We just don’t know it yet.



Unknown unknowns

High school you. Majors you’d never heard of. Some don’t exist yet.



The goal is clear. Now I need data. →

PHONES OUT. YES, REALLY.

Let’s collect some data. *Right now.*

5 questions · 60 seconds · Anonymous



pedramjahangiry.com/polls/mindsets

Let’s see what this room looks like. →

This room, right now

Open the live results ↗

Mindsets in this room · % numbers people · 8:30 vs 9:30

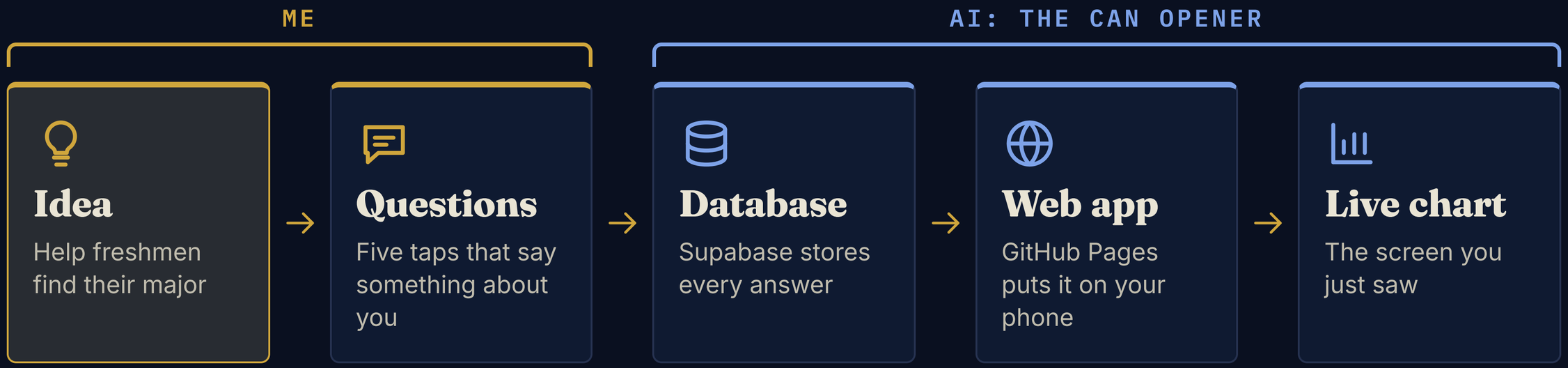
TURN AND TALK · 30 SEC

Tell your neighbor your result.

Did it get you right? Why or why not?

So how the heck did I build that? →

I had the idea. *Not the tools.*



So I assumed the can opener, **and went beyond it.**

This is what the future of work looks like. →

A FEW YEARS AGO

A team of developers
A semester
A budget

THIS FALL

One professor
14 minutes
AI

The can opener is *real.*



You'll get paid for the **"then what?"** Analyze. Think. Solve.

So: do you want to build the opener, or use it? →

Build the opener, or *use it?*



BUILD IT

Major in data

Curious how the opener works? We'll teach you to build it, faster.

Data Analytics · Information Systems



USE IT

Add the data minor

More excited about what you can open? Pair it with any major.

Either way, data goes with you. →

Data × every major

Accounting × *data*

Catch the odd transaction before the auditor does.

Pro Sales & Marketing × *data*

Know which customer to call first, and which ad actually worked.

Management × *data*

See what's really working on your team, not just what feels like it.

Econ & Finance × *data*

Test the theory and the strategy before you bet the money.

Major or minor, data multiplies whatever you pick. **Data is the mindset.**

So what is the can opener, really? →

BE EXCITED, NOT SCARED

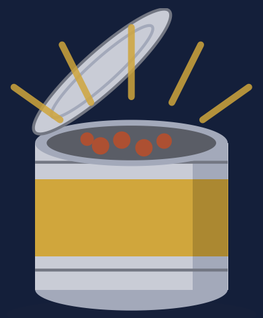
The can opener is *AI.*

- Yes, it will take a lot of jobs.
- It will open a lot of new ones.
- **Then what?** Stay adaptable. Train your thinking. Go beyond the surface.



A computer beat the world chess champion in 1997. **We still play chess. We love it.**

So whatever you pick, pick what excites you. →



You don’t have to assume the can opener anymore.

What will you *open?*

Retake it. Share it.